Meeting Brezhnev on 18 May 1970, Honecker testified the transition of power in East Berlin had been stable. From here on, his relationship with the Soviet leader became psychologically interesting. Honecker's office was adorned by a portrait of Brezhnev with a personal dedication, as was the lobby of the SED building (his office was remodelled by Elli Kelm's husband to his personal specifications). It didn't take long for Honecker to cement his place as a Kremlin favourite by cosying up to the leadership at any given opportunity – he often closely and carefully scoured pages of Brezhnev's writing and speeches for guidance on how to create the most acceptable impression. It is known Brezhnev developed different degrees of closeness with his East European comrades, but according to Brezhnev's bodyguard, V.T. Medvedev, Honecker sought hardest to ingratiate himself, while Romania's Ceaușescu behaved as if he were head of the Warsaw Pact. Travelling as if a Roman Emperor making a world tour, the Romanian always showed up for half a day of talks in the Crimea with his own cooks, food and bottled water. Brezhnev's son-in-law, Yuri Churbanov, confirmed that his father-in-law disliked Ceaușescu and 'all of that Romanian socialism', but remained on good terms with Honecker, Husak and Zhivkov.

For the new First Secretary, portraying the image of a modern man was important. During those early days, he abandoned drab off-the-peg suits for garments cut by the finest 'diplomatic tailors' in Alexanderplatz. From then on, he donned bespoke light grey and blue outfits and colourful silk ties. When the 'new' Honecker took to the podium for the eighth Party Congress in May, he was greeted by a standing ovation after declaring the main task of the five-year plan from 1971 to 1975 was to 'further raise the material and cultural standard of living of the people'.2 As an expression of gratitude for Brezhnev's benevolence, he declared that consultations with the USSR had 'intensified systematically', and would lead to absolute unanimity on questions of ideology and foreign policy. Across the airwaves, listeners heard his promise of far-reaching changes and a better standard of living. 'We only know one goal that permeates the entire policy of our party: to do everything for the good of man, the happiness of the people, for the interests of the working class and of the working population.' Applause greeted his announcement of a massive building programme that, he said, would see the construction, modernisation and conversion of 500,000 apartments over the next five years. In closing, he again expressed gratitude